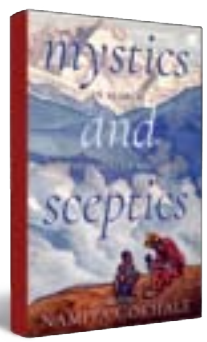
BOOKS

A Way Out OF OUR *Fragmented* LANDSCAPE

A collection of 25 essays offers a peek into the **Himalaya** from the perspective of Himalayan people



MYSTICS AND SCEPTICS
In Search of Himalayan Masters
Edited by Namita Gokhale
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹699; 328 pages



A REVIEW OF THREE RECENT BOOKS ON the Himalaya earlier this month opened with the provocation: 'Whose Himalaya is it?' Surveying writing on the Himalaya from the earliest colonial encounters to the present day, Amish Raj Mulmi (*Himal Southasian*, March 1, 2023) found that "indigenous modes of seeing are rarely found in contemporary Western popular writing about the Himalaya". The massif and its inhabitants have been variously exoticised, marginalised, and vilified.

An anthology like *Mystics and Sceptics: In Search of Himalayan Masters* offers the necessary corrective to these 'ways of seeing' by foregrounding the lived spiritual experience of Himalayan people, their relationships to the natural and supernatural worlds, and to each other. A child of the central Himalaya herself, editor Namita Gokhale's upbringing among the "spiritualists... [of] divine understanding, intuitive prowess and mystical powers" helped her "move outside the blinkered worldview of an anglicised middle-class education".

A collection of 25 essays, by no means encyclopaedic, the editor concedes, offers a peek into the spiritual and material worlds of women and men of uncommon wisdom, whose careers unfolded in the Himalaya—variously functioning as a place of residence, travel and adventure, or imagination. They are penned by some of the finest contemporary scholars in the field of Tibetan and Himalayan studies: Holly Gayley, Ranjit Hoskote, Sujata Prasad and Andrew Quintman, to name a few. In particular, the closing chapter by Vaibhav Kaul, parts of which are adapted from his doctoral dissertation, is a triumph of scholarship, writing and utopian vision.

The collection is ambitious in both its spatial and temporal sweep. The chapters are organised chronologically, though the spread is hardly even. It opens in the eighth century with Yeshe Tsogyal, but less than a fourth of the way through, we are already knocking at the 20th with Swami Vivekananda. Nine of the 25 chapters are focused on Tibet and Tibetan masters. Some—Milarepa and the Tibetologist Alexander David-Néel—even get two chapters, and there are two on the Dalai Lamas (13th and 14th). No complaints there! In contrast, fewer than a fourth of the contributions are on Kashmir, Nepal, Sikkim and Bhutan combined. Taken together, the Tibetan section is the strongest part of the anthology.

Mystics and Sceptics foregrounds the lived spiritual experience of Himalayan people

Gokhale points out that the "joint strands of Indian and Tibetan tantric understanding" run through the book, which is truly syncretic and expansive in its ethos. But among the many omissions of names, places and themes that an anthology of this scope must necessarily contend with, there is one that I find particularly regrettable. With the exception of chapters on Guru Nanak and Guru Gobind Singh (Navtej Sarna), the keepers of U Thlen (Bijoya Sawian) and part of a chapter on the Sufi *pir*s of Pir Panjal (Vaibhav Kaul), the anthology is almost entirely devoted to Hindu and Buddhist cosmologies—admittedly internally diverse and heterodox in themselves—to the neglect of others.

Three Kashmiri Muslims come immediately to mind, whose presence would have enriched the volume and expanded its geographical reach north- and westward. Mohammad Iqbal immortalised the Himalaya for generations of Indian children singing '*sare jahan se achcha*' in their school assemblies, and identified it as the fountainhead of the subcontinent's syncretism and strength. In a poem titled 'Himala' (1905), Iqbal called the massif "*fasil-e-kishvar-e-hindustan*", or 'the bulwark of Hindustan'. Agha Shahid Ali also sang of our interconnected provenance: "My ancestor, a man/ of Himalayan snow,/ came to Kashmir from Samarkand,/ carrying a bag/ of whale bones:/ heirlooms from sea funerals." And Abdul Wahid of the Radhu clan, whose ancestor was an initiate into the Chishti *silsila* (Sufi order) of Kashmir, and whose family had secured the right to carry the triennial tribute (*lo phyag*) and homage from the Ladakhi kings—over a thousand miles—to the Dalai Lama in Lhasa.

These 'forgotten friendships' and 'heteroglot genealogies', to borrow from historian Indrani Chatterjee, can help us map the relational universe of the Himalaya and offer a way out of the fragmented landscape of our present. We owe Gokhale and her contributors a debt of gratitude for charting that way for us. ■

Swati Chawla